The chapter contains five major sections. It begins with a brief discussion of the common paradoxes and complexities involved in deciding how to conceptualize "power" in international relations. The second section moves to explain the focus on material power capabilities as the best path to understanding the importance of the BRICS, exploring their significance from three perspectives: as an improbable, yet consequential, international club, which may be usefully compared to the G7; in terms of the China–United States duo; and by means of the intra-BRICS capability distribution. The third section directly asks whether these shifts constitute a genuine evolution toward global multipolarity and lays out some of the related analytical puzzles that would need to be resolved before such a determination was made. In the fourth section, the discussion turns to examining the BRICS monetary and financial capabilities, which generally lag the shifts in relative economic weight, yet may be significant in the future (e.g., if they engage in more assertive or offensive financial statecraft going forward). Finally, the fifth section considers the rise of China's currency: the renminbi (RMB), also known as the "redback."

CONCEPTUALIZING POWER

Most contemporary academic approaches to power dismiss a simple aggregation of capabilities and tangible resources, recognizing that a state's possession of economic or military resources does not automatically confer international leadership or translate into a greater or lesser impact on international outcomes or on how other actors behave.[9] The weak sometimes defeat the strong in armed conflicts, midsized states regularly withhold cooperation from more resolute, powerful allies, and greater strength in one domain does not necessarily convert to usable power and influence in another. Whereas liberals assume that absolute economic gains are primarily wealth enhancing, interdependence can be asymmetrical in situations in which one side would lose more from a disruption, creating potential leverage by the other.[10] Realists also emphasize the fungibility of economic resources, which permit relative gains by states if they are converted into military and geoeconomic power.[11] In this way, large rising economies may emerge as potential challengers to the interests of incumbent powers. Likewise, incumbent power-holders can resist changes that reduce their influence and authority in international institutions long past their prime in the panoplies of power rankings.

Scholars often prefer definitions of "power" privileging either relational power between and among actors, or structural power. *Relational power* implies that actor A is able to persuade, coerce, or offer material incentives to induce actor B to behave in ways that B otherwise would not have freely chosen. State A may exercise relational power over state B because B depends on A for military protection, trade, investment, or international status.[12] Relational power traditionally implies *influence*, which may involve pushing others to do something, but also may cause actors to redefine their interests in response to changed perceptions and incentives. Influence thus may involve the use of what Nye calls "soft power" as a means of "getting others to want what you want."[13] *Autonomy*—defined as the ability of one state to resist or ignore the attempts of another state to induce, persuade, or coerce it into altering behavior—is also a particularly important variety of relational power in an era characterized by rising multipolarity (or perhaps bipolarity-multipolarity). States seek the capacity for autonomous action and national policy independence. Autonomy becomes particularly important in a historical epoch in which interstate relative power shifts are becoming more significant. Following Benjamin J. Cohen and David Andrews, autonomy can be seen as a type of passive power that is a by-product of capabilities, whereas *influence* involves "purposeful acts" to shape the behavior of others.[14]

Structural power confers a special form of control, which both Susan Strange and Lloyd Gruber equate with changing the choices opened or closed to other actors.[15] Strange defined it as the power "to shape and determine the structures of the global political economy . . . to decide how things shall be done, [and] the power to shape frameworks within which states relate to each other… ."[16] According to Bachrach and Baratz, structural power inheres in social institutions, whose formal and informal rules of procedure tend to privilege certain actors while undermining others.[17] Various international structures may be identified, including the financial structure: "the sum of all the arrangements governing the availability of credit plus all factors determining the terms on which currencies are exchanged for each other."[18] Similarly, network power, or the influence accruing to an actor sitting at a node or bridge that provides valuable and otherwise scarce links to other actors, may be exercised both by the incumbent representatives of sovereign states and by nonstate actors.[19] In an age of multiplying and globalized international economic links, network power has become an ever-more-significant form of structural power that amplifies and reinforces American preponderance.

The dynamics of influence, autonomy, and structural power all come into sharper relief during power shifts. Preponderant powers tend to be more satisfied with the status quo and can behave as more or less cooperative and benevolent hegemons—yet those lower in the hierarchy are likely to resent second-class citizenship. Rising powers